

played all of 15 Tests. That South Africa's frontline Test campaigners had to miss the series to honour their contractual obligations to SA20 — the country's marquee franchise T20 league — didn't sit well with the purists. Their absence resulted in the Kiwis running riot and securing their first-ever Test series win against the Proteas.

South Africa's resurgence from that nadir was marked by a resilient run, which included contending with a depleted pace-bowling attack on seam-friendly tracks at home. And while their spot in the WTC final shouldn't be up for debate, the Proteas' campaign warrants scrutiny of the WTC's format and structure.

A cursory glance at the standings points to a fundamental discrepancy that threatens the fairness of any league across sports. Table-topper South Africa played just 12 Tests in the 2023-25 cycle, the joint-lowest with Bangladesh, while England featured in 22 matches in the same timeframe. To adjust for the unequal number of matches, the International Cricket Council (ICC) had devised the percentage of points won (PCT) system after the inaugural 2019-21 championship. While the grading system satisfies statistical logic, it doesn't account for more subjective variables such as length of series, quality of opponents, and diversity of



Top of the world: Australia is the defending World Test Champion, having beaten India at The Oval in 2023. REUTERS

conditions. All six of South Africa's series in the current cycle comprised two matches each, and 12 of its 17 series since the advent of the WTC have been two-Test duels. The fewer number of matches in a series limits exposure to the most gruelling format of the game and reduces opportunities to test bench strength and expand the player pool. Moreover, it diminishes the ability to gather momentum and peaking, either to extend dominance or stage a fightback. A case in point is India's tour of South Africa in 2023-24, which ended in a 1-1 draw after the visitor won by seven wickets at Cape Town in what is

still the shortest completed Test match ever. In short, a two-match Test series often ends on a note of unfulfilment and leaves much to the imagination. "Our Test team is playing two-Test series, which is ridiculous in my eyes. It's disappointing, and it doesn't sit well with the players because we want to play more cricket against these guys [India]...", former South Africa batter Heinrich Klaasen had lamented during a T20I series against India that followed the Tests. While South Africa and Bangladesh are the only teams to have only played two-match Test series in the 2023-25 cycle, New Zealand, Pakistan,

Team-wise distribution of series in WTC era (2019-2025)

